

Cognition is adaptive, not representational.

Knowledge is viable (it works), not true (it mirrors reality).

There is no categorial scheme — categories are constructions, contingent on the cognizing subject.

Traditional ontology assumes...
the assumption shared by all twelve preceding pages

Categories track reality
kinds carve the world at its joints

Truth = correspondence
a proposition is true iff it matches reality

Knowledge = representation
mind mirrors what is the case

Cognition is finding
the world is given; we discover its structure

Reality is independently accessible
we can know how things are in themselves

Radical Constructivism claims...
Glasersfeld's counter-position

Categories are constructed
by the cognizing subject, in coordinating experience

Viability replaces truth
a construct survives if it works — like a key fitting a lock

Cognition is adaptive
mind builds models that fit experience, not reality

Cognition is making
verum ipsum factum (Vico): we know what we make

Reality is inaccessible as such
whatever is "out there" cannot be known apart from our constructions

Lineage: Vico (1710) → Kant (constituting categories) → Piaget (genetic epistemology) → von Foerster, Maturana (cybernetics) → Glasersfeld
Downstream: constructivist pedagogy (Piaget, Papert) · second-order cybernetics · autopoietic theory (Maturana & Varela) · enactivism
NOT: social constructionism (Berger & Luckmann) · postmodern relativism — RC is an epistemology, not a sociology of knowledge

meta-position · no categorial tree · questions the very enterprise of the preceding 12 pages